MODULE 8: Pre-bunking & Debunking

Objective
To help participants understand:
- What prebunking is and why it matters.
- How to debunk false information responsibly.
- When prebunking is more effective and when debunking is necessary.
- How to contribute positively to addressing false information as informed citizens.

8.1 What Is Prebunking?
Prebunking is an approach that raises awareness before false information spreads, helping people recognise misleading content when they encounter it in the future.
In simple terms:
Prebunking acts like a "vaccine against misinformation."
It teaches people:
- The techniques used to spread false information.
- The warning signs that should prompt closer scrutiny.
- Why emotionally charged content requires caution.

8.2 Why Is Prebunking Effective?
Research and practical experience indicate that:
- False information can be difficult to correct once it has spread.
- Changing an established belief can take time.
- Advance awareness helps people prepare mentally to recognise misleading information.

Prebunking can therefore be more effective than debunking in many situations.

8.3 Key Elements of Prebunking
An effective prebunking approach generally includes:
- Introducing common manipulation techniques, such as exaggeration, fear appeals, and emotional provocation.
- Highlighting warning signs.
- Providing simple examples.
- Explaining how false information spreads.

This helps people become more alert when they encounter similar content in the future.

8.4 Practical Examples of Prebunking
Examples include:
- "Verify content that provokes strong fear or anger before sharing it."
- "Be cautious when a claim is supported only by a screenshot."
- "Do not accept important claims without checking official sources."

These messages help people recognise potential risks in advance.

8.5 What Is Debunking?
Debunking is the process of correcting false or misleading information after it has spread, using accurate information and evidence.

In simple terms:
Debunking means countering false information with facts.

8.6 When Is Debunking Necessary?
Debunking is necessary when:
- False information has already spread.
- People have begun to believe it.
- The issue concerns the public interest, civic rights, or social harmony.

However, debunking is not always necessary or effective.

8.7 Principles of Effective Debunking
Responsible debunking requires following several important principles:
1. Use Calm and Respectful Language
Angry or insulting language can make people defensive.

2. Clearly Identify the Error
Explain precisely which part of the information is incorrect.

3. Provide Accurate Information
Use credible and official sources.

4. Avoid Unnecessary Repetition
Repeatedly restating false information may amplify its spread.

8.8 Prebunking vs. Debunking

Aspect	Pre-bunking	Debunking
Timing	Before	After
Goal	Prevention	Correction
Risk	Lower	Relatively higher
Effectiveness	Long-term	Depends on the situation

8.9 Importance in the Bangladesh Context
Prebunking and debunking are important in Bangladesh because:
- Social media often serves as a primary source of information.
- Rumours spread rapidly.
- A strong culture of verification has yet to become established.

Raising awareness in advance about elections, public services, and social issues can help prevent widespread confusion.

8.10 Our Role as Citizens
As informed citizens, we can:
- Raise awareness by sharing prebunking messages.
- Reduce confusion through responsible debunking.
- Break the chain of false information.

Choosing not to respond can sometimes be a responsible decision.